is a Burgher, a Sri Lankan ethnic group of European origin. A salesman and DJ by profession, he had moved to Bahrain in the 1980s. Her mother Kim is of Malaysian and Canadian descent and is a former air hostess. The youngest of four children, Jacqueline studied mass communication in Australia. In 2006, she was crowned Miss Universe Sri Lanka. The 37-year-old actress came to India in 2009 for a modelling assignment (see *Jacqueline in a Jam*).

Lodged in Rohini jail, Sukash first contacted Jacqueline through her make-up artiste Shaan Muttathil, whom he called from a landline number in December 2020. Identifying himself as a senior official from the home ministry, he insisted that Jacqueline talk to one Shekhar Ratna Vela from Chennai, a relative of former Tamil Nadu CM Jayalalithaa, and whose family owned Sun TV. When Shaan checked the number, he found it to be from the home ministry. Sukash had yet again successfully employed the spoofing tech to convince Jacqueline and her team that the instruction had indeed come out of the home ministry.

The credentials thus established, Jacqueline agreed to talk to Shekhar and by the end of January 2021 received a call from Shekhar alias Sukash. During their conversations, 'Shekhar' told Jacqueline that he was friends with Leonardo DiCaprio and could get her a role opposite the Oscar-winning actor in a Hollywood production.

Within two weeks of their first call, Shaan alerted Jacqueline about a news article featuring a person who looked very much like Sukash. When confronted, Sukash denied the report, claiming it was a political conspiracy to taint him and even broke down over the phone. Later, his accomplice and celebrity manager, Pinky Irani, also assured Jacqueline of Sukash's innocence.

Meanwhile, the conman got interim bail for two weeks on June 4, 2021, which was later extended to July 2, 2021. In this one month, Jacqueline came to meet Sukash twice in Chennai, per the ED chargesheet. The photographs currently doing the rounds were allegedly taken at this time. Jacqueline, however, says that she met Sukash only once and that too because he was depressed following his uncle's death. Shekhar alias Sukash had told her that it was his uncle, and not his father (for whose demise Sukash had got the bail), who had passed away. The communication between Sukash and Jacqueline ended following his arrest in August 2021.

But Jacqueline wasn't Sukash's only preoccupation in the time that he was out on interim bail. He was also allegedly busy conning ex-Telugu Desam MP Rayapati Sambasiva Rao. Accused in a bank fraud case, Rao was promised relief in return for money, claims the CBI, which is probing the case. Two of Sukash's accomplices have been arrested in connection with the case.

In his conversations with Jacqueline, Sukash allegedly told her he was friends with Leonardo DiCaprio and would get her a role in one of his films

SUKASH THE CORPORATE LOBBYIST?

Despite the wealth of allegations against him, there is little to force Sukash to confess. He has already denied the charges of fraud and money-laundering against him. "I have made hundreds of crores from corporate lobbying, there is no need for me to con or cheat anyone... It's all from legitimate earnings and the same would be proved in the court of law very soon," he wrote in the letter to the media. His lawyer Ashok Kumar Singh claims he earns money through real estate, consultation, brokerage, a salon and resort that he runs. Indeed, despite the 30-plus cases against him, he has not been convicted in a single one till date. In some of them, even the trials have not begun. The sections under which he has been charged attract a maximum imprisonment of 10 years, and most are bailable. His problems may begin now, after he has been booked under PMLA, where getting bail is next to impossible even though conviction carries a maximum of seven years in jail. Besides confiscating 26 cars, the ED has also attached Rs 13.21 crore lying in various bank accounts linked to Sukash.

But then, anything is possible if you are Sukash Chandrashekhar. Between June 2018 and July 2021, he was officially out of jail, either on parole or on interim bail, first on account of his father's ill health, then his mother's illness, and finally to perform his father's last rites, for nearly 300 days. He got bail from both the Supreme Court and the high courts, with top lawyers such as Mukul Rohatgi moving his bail applications.

All of which has perhaps bred a God complex in the man. Usually suave and soft-spoken and easily able to persuade his victims with smooth talk, Sukash allegedly turns aggressive and abusive when met with resistance. Some of his accomplices have told the police that he threatens them with dire consequences if they disobey his instructions, and is capable of executing the threats too. One such threat haunts Aditi Singh even today. When a crying Aditi had expressed her inability to pay any more and requested Sukash to spare her family or she would be forced to take her life, he told her heartlessly: "Sister, we will not let you live, and we will not let you die. We are God." Posing as God. You cannot put it past him. ■

with ***Ajay Sukumaran***